9

The Aborted Heliborne Commando Operation

R.N. KAO, during his nine years (1968–77) as head of the R&AW and director general, security (DGS), was well aware of the capabilities of the elite SFF (Special Frontier Force, an adjunct of a bigger group known as Establishment 22) commando unit to handle hostage taking and other terrorism-related activities. As the R&AW and DGS were both part of the cabinet secretariat, functioning directly under the charge of the prime minster, Indira Gandhi of course knew the purpose for which SFF was originally raised. When the situation was hotting up in Punjab in the latter half of 1982, Kao began contemplating an SFF-led heliborne operations to remove Bhindranwale from Chowk Mehta gurudwara, and later, from the Golden Temple complex with as little loss of life and property as possible.

As mentioned earlier, I was at that time handling the additional charge of the liaison division, dealing with representatives of some of the foreign intelligence agencies posted at the various missions in New Delhi. In those days, all requests for meetings with liaison contacts, including those from the IB, were handled by the head of the liaison division of the R&AW. In addition to arranging such meetings, the head had to be personally present. Only the director (R), and later, its successor post secretary (R), could meet these liaison contacts alone without the presence of the liaison division head. This arrangement changed in the 1990s, when a decision was